

NEW YORK

Towering Mess

RATING ★ ★ ☆ ☆ ☆

Director: Kabir Khan

Starring: John Abraham, Neil Nitin Mukesh, Katrina Kaif



I have a letter from the FBI," says Neil Nitin Mukesh. "Yeah," says John Abraham through his tears, standing on top of a New York skyscraper surrounded by helicopters carrying FBI snipers training their guns on him, and "these are your postmen". This is the

moment that should tear you up, having been preceded by several scenes where Abraham has been stripped, handcuffed, isolated in a tiny cell, been peed upon, and waterboarded. But there's nothing, nada. That's pretty much the feeling throughout the movie even as sirens blare, gunshots resound and helicopters whirr. What

starts off as a campus romance in golden-hued New York ends as a supposed dark reading of what it means to be a Muslim in post-9/11 America.

Bollywood's Muslim, from the *bhaijan* to the *bhai*, has never had so many shades of grey as in Abraham's Samir, so it's a pity the film is unable to give wings to its leaden emotions. The only moving moment occurs right at the end when the good Muslim cop, played with irony by Irrfan, looks at Abraham's son winning a baseball match and being feted by his teammates. "Only in America would the son of a Muslim terrorist be a hero for his American mates in an all-American game." And only in Bollywood could such a powerful idea fall flat on its face. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

IF YOU HAVE 90 MINUTES to see a dance-maths dialogue, then there's nothing better than the Performing Dance Company. At Kamani Auditorium, Delhi, July 10.

KELKAR IN CHARACTER

THEATRE

Common Cause

Cartoonist R. K. Laxman's popular, witty and profound Common Man is on stage, for a unique audio-visual presentation. It is written by Anil Joglekar and translated into English by Gautam Joglekar under the name of R. K. Laxman's *The Common Man*. Director and producer Ajit Kelkar also plays the nameless lead and journeys through India's political history since 1947. As part of the endeavour, Kelkar selects cartoons and adds voice-overs, songs and anecdotes to add context for the audience. One such cartoon refers to Krishna Menon, the Indian ambassador who was mocked for visiting every city in the world and not visiting Delhi; where the conflict between Menon and Laxman is presented via voice-overs. This production remains true to the nature of the cartoons they stem from. From July 7 to 8, at Prithvi Theatre, Mumbai.

by Pankti Mehta

MUSIC REVIEW

Old is Gold

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Salilda, as he was fondly addressed, had the knack of fusing elements of Western symphony with folk music and Indian classical music. Lata Mangeskar counts Salil Chowdhury's songs as her favourites. He, in turn, loved her singing. "I never felt the need to turn to anyone else," Salil would say. Be it *Aaj nahin koi apna* (*Annadata*) or *Jago Mohan pyare* (*Jagte Raho*) or *Ja re ja re ud ja re panchi* (*Maya*), each composition was well-crafted. "His compositions were difficult and challenging," says Mangeskar. In this rare collection of 40 songs, you can hear songs that are not available on any other cassette or CD. Listen to them to get a taste of pure melody and creative orchestra work.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit